absolutely fundamental to limiting the power of investigative agencies—only came together in the early twentieth century, i.e., 154 years after the founding of the country. It was only in the 1970s that US lawmakers shut off domestic operations by the CIA, and brought electronic surveillance by investigative agencies under the rule of law.

Similarly, it took seventy years from 1947 for India to decriminalize gay sex. Assuming there is progress towards freedom and the rule of law in the future, it will prove to take over seventy years to get to basic elements of civil liberties including decriminalization of defamation, removal of sedition from the IPC, and placing electronic surveillance of the populace under a rule of law framework. These are long and slow journeys.

We should not look for the newspaper headlines, the quick wins, the buzz on social media. We should instead dig into the long and slow process of genuinely building the republic.

Summing up

When a policy reform takes place, the full gains are obtained through the reallocation of resources in the economy. Policy reform requires private persons to fully internalize the new environment, and re-optimize for it. Many policy reforms require the construction of institutional capacity within government and in the economy. These adjustments take time. For this reason, the pain is front-loaded and the gains come with a lag. Policymakers need to understand who will lose in the short run, negotiate with them, and find compromises with them.

After elections take place, and the leadership faces a five-year horizon, it is useful to think of year 1 as the time to launch complex initiatives, which will mature through years 2, 3 and 4, and show positive impacts by year 5. This imposes demands on the team formed after the elections. It needs to choose the major projects, staff them, and communicate this to the economy so as to reshape expectations. This requires considerable work within political parties before winning the election.